UNIT III - CONVERSATIONAL SKILLS

Conversation is a two-way exchange of ideas, information and feelings. Good conversational skill is built on correct language, clear pronunciation, polite manners, active listening and confidence. This unit moves from everyday conversation to prepared and unprepared speeches.

1. Basics of Conversation

(a) Greetings

A greeting opens a conversation and sets the tone. Choose it according to the time, the person and the situation.

Situation	Expressions	Reply
Formal, morning/afternoon/evening	Good morning / Good afternoon / Good evening, Sir.	Good morning. How are you?
Informal	Hi! / Hello! / Hey, how's it going?	Hi! I'm fine, thanks. And you?
First meeting	How do you do? / Pleased to meet you.	How do you do? / Pleased to meet you too.
Meeting after a long time	It's so good to see you again!	Lovely to see you too!
Parting	Goodbye. / See you later. / Take care.	Bye! See you soon.
Festivals and occasions	Happy Pongal! / Congratulations! / Best wishes!	Thank you. Same to you.

(b) Introductions

- **Introducing yourself:** state your name, where you are from, what you do or study, and one interesting detail. *Hello, I am Ravi. I am from Puducherry. I am studying BCA, and I enjoy photography.*
- **Introducing others:** Say the name of the person you are introducing to the other person, and a short detail. In formal situations, mention the elder or senior person first: *Sir, may I introduce my friend Kumar? Kumar, this is Professor Rao.*
- **Responses:** *Nice to meet you. / Pleased to meet you. / I have heard a lot about you.*
- Smile, make eye contact and give a firm handshake (or a polite namaste) in formal introductions.

(c) Asking questions

There are two main types of questions:

- **Yes/no questions** begin with an auxiliary verb and are answered with yes or no: *Do you like music? Have you finished?*
- **Wh-questions** begin with what, where, when, who, whom, whose, why, which, how and ask for information: *Where do you work? How long have you lived here?*
- **Open questions** invite longer answers (*What do you think about online classes?*); **closed questions** get short answers.
- **Polite forms:** *Could you tell me the way to the library? Would you mind closing the window? Excuse me, may I ask something?*
- **Question tags:** *It's a nice day, isn't it? You don't smoke, do you?*

(d) Keeping a conversation going

- Answer fully and add a little more information, then ask a question back.
- Use small responses to show interest: *Really? I see. That's interesting. Is that so?*

- Take turns; do not dominate or interrupt.
- Choose safe, common topics: weather, studies, hobbies, food, travel, festivals.
- To close politely: *It was nice talking to you. I must go now. See you soon.*

Sample dialogue: meeting a new classmate

Priya: Good morning! I don't think we have met. I am Priya.

Arun: Good morning, Priya. I am Arun. Are you new here?

Priya: Yes, I joined the college last week. Which department are you in?

Arun: I am in Computer Applications. And you?

Priya: I am in the same department! Could you tell me where the computer lab is?

Arun: Of course. It is on the second floor. I'll show you.

Priya: Thank you so much. That's very kind of you.

Arun: You're welcome. Nice meeting you. See you in class!

Sample dialogue: asking for directions

Tourist: Excuse me, could you tell me how to get to the railway station?

Local: Certainly. Go straight for two hundred metres, turn left at the signal, and you will see it on your right.

Tourist: Is it far from here?

Local: No, it is only a five-minute walk.

Tourist: Thank you very much.

2. Describing People, Places, Situations and Events

Description paints a picture in words. To describe well, observe carefully, choose exact words and organise your points in a logical order.

Describing people

- **Physical features:** age, height, build, face, hair, dress.
- **Personality:** kind, honest, shy, cheerful, stubborn, humorous.
- **Habits and actions:** what the person usually does or says.
- **Your feeling:** why the person is special to you.

Sample

My grandmother is a short, slim woman in her seventies with silver hair and a warm smile. She wears a simple cotton sari and always smells of jasmine. She is kind and patient, and she wakes up before sunrise to prepare breakfast for everyone. Her stories are the best part of my evenings. I admire her strength and her love for the family.

Describing places

- Say where it is and how big it is.
- Describe what you see, hear, smell and feel.
- Move in order: near to far, outside to inside, or left to right.
- End with the overall impression.

Sample

Our village lies beside a quiet river, surrounded by green paddy fields. In the morning, the air is cool and filled with birdsong. At the centre stands an old banyan tree where elders gather in the evenings. It is a peaceful place, and I always feel relaxed when I return.

Describing situations and events

- Answer the questions: what happened, when, where, who was involved and why.
- Use time connectors: first, then, after that, meanwhile, finally.
- Use the past tense for events that are over, and the present tense for what is happening now.
- Add feelings and reactions to make it lively.

Sample: describing an event

Last Sunday, our college held its annual sports day. First, the Chief Guest hoisted the flag, and the students marched past. Then the races began; the crowd cheered loudly for every runner. Finally, prizes were given, and everyone went home tired but happy.

3. Extempore Speeches

An **extempore speech** is a speech given on the spot, with little or no preparation, usually after a minute or two of thinking time. It tests quick thinking, vocabulary, confidence and organisation.

How to prepare in a short time

- **Understand the topic** and decide your angle in the first few seconds.
- **Choose three points** you can speak about, and note one example for each.
- **Plan the structure:** Opening (1 sentence) - Body (3 points) - Closing (1-2 sentences).
- **Start confidently** with a question, quote or fact.
- **Speak slowly**; pauses give you time to think and make you sound confident.
- If you lose the thread, return to your plan or summarise what you have said.
- Avoid fillers (umm, uh, you know) and avoid apologising.

Sample extempore: 'Importance of Time'

Opening: 'Time and tide wait for no man' - this old saying reminds us how precious time is.

Point 1: Time is limited; once lost it never returns. A student who wastes a year cannot get it back.

Point 2: Good use of time brings success. Those who plan their day achieve more.

Point 3: Punctuality earns respect in college, at work and in life.

Closing: So let us value every minute and make each day count. Thank you.

4. Persuasive and Descriptive Speeches

Persuasive speech

A persuasive speech tries to convince the audience to accept an idea or take an action. It uses facts, logic and emotion.

- **Structure:** Attention-getter - Statement of the problem - Solution - Evidence and examples - Call to action.
- **Techniques:** rhetorical questions, statistics, short stories, repetition, and a strong, confident tone.
- **Appeals:** *logic* (facts and reasons), *emotion* (feelings and values) and *credibility* (why they should trust you).
- Address the audience's possible objections politely.

Sample persuasive opening and close: 'Say no to plastic'

Opening: 'Every minute, a truck full of plastic ends up in our seas. Can we call ourselves responsible if we let this continue?'

Close: 'The change starts with one bag. Carry a cloth bag from tomorrow. Together we can keep our earth clean.'

Descriptive speech

A descriptive speech helps the audience see, hear, smell, taste and feel a person, place, object or experience. It uses vivid details and sensory language and does not try to persuade.

- **Structure:** Introduction (what you will describe) - Body (details in a logical order) - Conclusion (overall impression or meaning).
- Use specific adjectives, comparisons (similes: 'as calm as a lake') and the five senses.

	Persuasive	Descriptive
Purpose	To convince and move to action	To create a clear picture
Language	Strong, emotional, logical	Sensory, vivid, detailed
Main tool	Reasons, evidence, call to action	Imagery and sensory detail
Example topics	Why we should plant trees	My favourite place in the monsoon

5. Speaking Through Narration

Narration is telling a story or an account of events in an order. It may be a personal experience, a news report or an imagined story.

- **Setting:** time and place of the events. **Characters:** the people (or animals) involved.
- **Plot:** the sequence: beginning (introduction) - middle (problem, rising action and climax) - end (resolution).
- **Tense:** mostly past tense; use time words such as one day, suddenly, meanwhile, at last.
- **Voice:** vary pace, pitch and volume; slow down at suspense, raise the pitch for surprise.
- **Point of view:** first person (I) or third person (he/she).

Sample narration: a personal experience

Last year, I missed my train to Chennai by two minutes. I was upset, but a kind stranger told me about a bus that left from the same station. I ran to catch it and reached my destination only half an hour late. That day I learnt that every problem has a solution if we stay calm.

6. Narrating Stories and Describing Characters and Situations of the Story

Narrating a story

- Start with a hook that catches attention: 'It was a dark, stormy night when the strange knock came.'
- Introduce the setting and main characters briefly.
- Present the problem or conflict, build tension and reach the turning point (climax).
- Conclude with the outcome and, if suitable, the moral.
- Keep to the order of events, and do not give unnecessary details.

Describing characters in a story

- Give appearance, speech, behaviour and feelings.

- 'Show' the quality through action: instead of saying 'He was generous', say 'He gave his only coat to the beggar'.
- Mention how the character changes during the story.

Describing the situation

- Explain what problem or choice the character faces, and why it matters.
- Explain the cause and the effect of the situation.

Sample: a short story told in speech

The Honest Woodcutter. A poor woodcutter was cutting wood beside a river when his iron axe fell into the water. He sat down and wept. A river spirit appeared and brought him a golden axe, but he said, 'That is not mine.' It brought a silver one; again he refused. At last it showed him his iron axe, and he said, 'This is mine.' Pleased with his honesty, the spirit gave him all three axes. **Moral:** Honesty is the best policy.